Mental Health Outcomes among Discordant High School Students

Caitlyn Wright, BSW, Marla Eisenberg, ScD, MPH

University of Minnesota, Department of Pediatrics, Division of General Pediatrics and Adolescent Health

INTRODUCTION

- Gay, lesbian, and bisexual adolescents are more likely to experience poorer mental health outcomes than their straight counterparts.
- Little research has been conducted regarding mental health outcomes between concordant and discordant adolescents.
- Previous literature among other populations shows that discordance can be harmful to one's mental health.

Concordant: Sexual behaviors and sexual identity are consistent

Discordant: Sexual behaviors and sexual identity are inconsistent

Research Questions

- What is the association between discordance/concordance and mental health outcomes?
- How does race affect this association?

METHODS

- Data from the Minnesota Student Survey were used to determine demographics and mental health outcomes among a sample of 1227 sexually active 9th and 11th graders.
- Chi-square tests of association were used to measure the distribution of concordance/ discordance by sex, race/ethnicity, and grade level, and to determine the association between discordance and three mental health outcomes: self harm, suicidal ideation, and suicide attempt.
- Logistic regression was used to determine odds ratios between discordance/concordance and the three measures of mental health.

KEY FINDINGS

Sample characteristics

- The proportion of discordant males is over 3X the proportion of discordant females.
- The proportion of American Indian, African American, and Hispanic youth is notably greater than the proportion of White youth.
- The proportion of discordant 9th graders is greater than that of 11th graders.

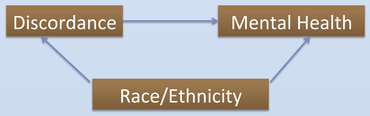
TABLE 1

	% Discordant
TOTAL SAMPLE	8.3
GENDER	*p<.0001*
Males	12.5
Females	3.8
RACE/ETHNICITY	*p<.0001*
American Indian	12.7
African American	14.4
Hispanic	11.4
White	7.2
GRADE	*p<.0001*
9th	11.0
11th	7.0

MODEL 1
Unadjusted



MODEL 2
Adjusted for Race/Ethnicity



MODEL 3
Adjusted for Race/Ethnicity and Grade



Mental Health Outcomes

- Discordance is positively associated with self-harming behavior, suicidal ideation and suicide attempts for females, and with self-harm for males (Table 2, Model 1).
- These associations persist upon adjustment for race/ ethnicity (Table 2, Model 2).
- The associations became non-significant when further adjusting for grade level, with the exception of suicide attempts among discordant females, who remained almost twice as likely to attempt suicide than concordant females (Table 2, Model 3).
- Discordant African American youth elicited better outcomes than discordant White youth on every measure of mental health.

TABLE 2

	SELF HARM			SUICIDAL IDEATION			SUICIDE ATTEMPT		
	Model 1	**Model 2**	**Model 3**	**Model 1**	**Model 2**	**Model 3**	**Model 1**	**Model 2**	**Model 3**
MALES									
Discordance	**1.28 (1.06-1.55)**	**1.26 (1.04-1.52)**	1.19 (.98-1.45)	.84 (.7-1)	.86 (.71-1.03)	.83 (.7-1)	1.18 (.93-1.51)	1.19 (.93-1.52)	1.16 (.91-1.49)
FEMALES									
Discordance	**1.36 (1.05-1.76)**	**1.35 (1.04-1.75)**	1.22 (.93-1.59)	**1.39 (1.08-1.78)**	**1.34 (1.04-1.72)**	1.24 (.96-1.6)	**2.02 (1.53-2.67)**	**1.91 (1.44-2.53)**	**1.78 (1.34-2.37)**

DISCUSSION

- Youth who identify as heterosexual but have same-sex partners are at increased risk of mental health problems, particularly among females.
- These associations were independent of race/ ethnicity, in spite of differences in discordance and mental health across race/ethnicity.
- These findings were explained in part by grade (likely a proxy for adolescent development).



IMPLICATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

- Framing **sexual exploration and identity formation as a normal and important part of adolescence** can help reduce the stigma associated with sexuality, particularly same-sex behaviors, and resulting psychological strain. Efforts targeted at those in middle adolescence may be especially important.
- More research is needed to understand the nature of discordance given secular trends toward the acceptance of a more open and fluid expression of sexuality, particularly for youth in certain cultural and social groups.
- More research is needed to understand the differences in discordance and mental health across racial/ethnic groups.

For Additional Information

Please contact Caitlyn at wrig0455@umn.edu

Acknowledgements

Supported by the Leadership Education in Adolescent Health (LEAH) Fellowship Training Program, University of Minnesota (grant T71-MC-00006, MCHB, HRSA, DHHS).

RESEARCH POSTER PRESENTATION DESIGN © 2012
www.PosterPresentations.com